Many senior financial policymakers in China call for the country to reform its domestic financial structure and strengthen the rule of law in domestic economic governance. Due to global market pressure, as well as the requirements from the international financial institutions to complete the inclusion of the RMB in the SDR and to achieve other goals, the Chinese leadership must continue to reform its financial sector—a process that has been resisted by state commercial banks, SOEs, and many other government entities.[91] Because domestic financial liberalization and reform are often viewed by the Chinese public as Western impositions, though, reformers have to play their hand carefully to avoid backlash.

However, when these reforms and liberalization moves become the prerequisite for China's stronger role in global financial governance, it becomes much easier for China's national leadership to push a domestic reform agenda forward. The BRICS members' support for making this process a part of global financial governance reform gives good cover for liberals in China to make progress in the financial reforms agreed to at the Third Plenum, held in Beijing in November 2013, without too much suspicion or pushback from the country's vested interests or popular nationalism.

Opportunities and Limits to China's Revisionist Agenda

Given these motivations to work together with the BRICS, should one characterize China as a fundamentally revisionist power in the global financial system?[92] Akin to all the BRICS countries, China benefits tremendously from the existing economic order; hence, it stands to lose significantly if the existing global economic order is destroyed. At the same time, as discussed previously, the relative importance of the Bretton Woods institutions for China has declined, and it is dissatisfied with the existing system, both in terms of its own level of representation and with respect to the normative and ideological underpinnings of the system. Ren Xiao argues that China is a "reform-minded status quo power" in the area of international financial governance in that, although it maintains the governance structure through the G20 and international financial institutions, China has also pushed to change unfair and flawed aspects of the current global financial order.[93] Another perspective suggests that China has outgrown the incumbent order in some respects and is less willing to